

autoimmune condition that attacks the body's nerves. It left him wheelchair-bound for two years. Yogesh never thought he'd walk, let alone play sports.

His mother, Meena Devi, a homemaker, and his father, Gyanchand Kathuniya, a retired Indian Army officer, didn't give up on him. Meena learned physiotherapy to assist her son and help with his recovery. Sure enough, in three years, Yogesh was on his feet again.

In 2016, a 19-year-old Yogesh discovered para sports with help from Sachin Yadav, the General Secretary of the student union at Kirori Mal College. Yadav introduced Yogesh to the world of para athletics, showing him videos of inspiring athletes from all over the world.

Two years later, Yogesh staked his claim in this universe with a world-record 45.18m throw in the F36 category at the 2018 European Championships in Berlin.

He would break the world record two more times in 2022, this time in the F56 category at the Indian Open National Para Athletic Championship, with the latest mark being a massive 48.34m throw on home soil.

Fight to be fit

Yogesh towers over his competition, some of whom are in wheelchairs, but his GBS diagnosis means he can never take feeling healthy for granted.

"I tire out very soon. I have a neurological disorder, so muscle loss happens very quickly for me. I need to focus a lot on my diet and my workout. Sometimes, if I work out too much, I have trouble walking. It's all about striking a balance."

Towards that end, Yogesh — previously a vegetarian — added eggs and meat to his diet to better meet his protein requirements, given that his sport requires muscle strength and explosiveness.

2023 brought with it more health issues for Yogesh. He contracted chickenpox early in the year and was

Hoping for a better reprise: Yogesh poses with his Tokyo Games silver medal. The Paris edition will be his third visit to the French capital, with each one marking a significant phase in the athlete's life. "The one thing I want to do this year, hopefully after winning my medal, is to go back to Disneyland and ride that roller coaster again," he chuckles. GETTYIMAGES

later diagnosed with cervical radiculopathy centred in the C4, C5, and C6 vertebrae. He fought through it to win a silver at the Asian Games.

"I had numbness in my left arm because of it. I didn't realise what was happening. The pain kept increasing. I was unable to sleep properly. There were times I had to sleep sitting up. Anytime I straightened my neck, I would have pain." Eventually, I went for an MRI and got this diagnosis. Surgery was initially suggested, but I wanted to handle this with just rehab. My doctors told me that there was an 85 per cent chance to sort this out without surgery, and thankfully, that's what happened.

"This injury caused a dip in my performance. For a long time, I couldn't understand what was happening. I then hired a mental conditioning coach who continues to work with me. I was told that I tend to focus on the end result too much without focusing on the process. It's something I've been working on to this day."

Eat, breathe, sleep sports

Yogesh's routine is simple and focused. He starts his day at 6 a.m. and fits in two hours of training in the morning. After breakfast, he returns home. Due to the heat in Delhi, he prefers to slot his second training session in the evening.

Yogesh, like his parents, is god-fearing and is soothing his nerves ahead of an important Paralympic campaign with some help from the Shiv Puran.

"In the run-up to the Olympics, I started reading the Shiv Puran and want to finish it before I leave for Paris. "I talk to God a lot. I can't tell you how many times I've asked God to change the colour of my medal. I have told God that if He stays with me and helps me get the job done in Paris, I'll install a *shivling* near my house."

Besides faith, one nagging ambition keeps Yogesh going — crossing the 50m barrier in discus throw. This particularly helps on days when he just isn't mentally ready to get up and seize the day.

"I don't have a plan B. My plan A — sports — is my only plan. Sometimes, if I wake up and don't feel motivated, I only think about the 50m mark, and that pushes me to get going again."